

Post-incident review PIR-2025-063

Mobile Backend: elevated error rates

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 27 March 2025, Mobile Backend experienced elevated error rates in production (Southeast Asia) for about 12 minutes. The error-rate alert paged the on-call engineer. Investigation found that a feature flag was switched on for every tenant instead of the pilot group.

Impact

Users of Mobile Backend saw elevated error rates for about 12 minutes. The service owner, Mobile Engineering, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:17 First signal received.
- 09:21 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:49 Likely cause identified.
- 10:28 Mitigation applied.
- 10:47 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a feature flag was switched on for every tenant instead of the pilot group.

No dependency outages were reported by upstream providers during the window.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Assign a named owner for the component in the service catalogue.
- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.